

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE
WASHINGTON, D.C. 20250

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1. PURPOSE

- a. The United States Department of Agriculture (USDA) is committed to using performance measurement, data analysis, and evaluation to achieve the most effective and efficient program outcomes and greater accountability. Per the *Foundations for Evidence-Based Policymaking Act of 2018* ([Public Law \(P.L.\) 115-435](#), the “*Evidence Act*”), this Departmental Regulation (DR) establishes the policy, best practices, and requirements for evaluations for the Department. Such best practices and requirements will help the Department better characterize and account for the ways resources are used, who benefits, and to achieve Mission Area, agency, and enterprise-level goals and objectives. The purpose of the policy is to give USDA employees, partners, and stakeholders a common framework and approach to designing, conducting, and using evaluations.
- b. USDA can strengthen accountability and ease continuous learning through its evidence-building activities. A key goal of this policy is to establish best practices and standards for evaluations that ensure performance and meaningful outcomes for all people and communities we serve. Another goal is to educate USDA stakeholders on the benefits of using evaluation findings to measure program and project effectiveness, relevance, and efficiency. This includes partnering with USDA stakeholders in building capacity

for evaluation and evidence-based framework so together we can build a system that enables USDA to budget, plan, design programs, drive investments, and improve outcomes. Stronger evaluation and evidenced-based policy would result in better program delivery, continual process improvement, and improved budgetary prioritization and decisions. Strong evaluations can build knowledge and allow for the correction, improvement, risk management, and efficient delivery of programs and operational support.

2. SPECIAL INSTRUCTIONS AND CANCELLATIONS

- a. All Departmental directives that reference program evaluation must follow and keep to the standards stated in this policy.
- b. Evaluation policies and procedures implemented by individual Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices must follow and keep to the standards stated in this DR.

3. SCOPE

- a. Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will conduct evaluations at the agency level. The Office of Budget and Program Analysis (OBPA) will act as the lead office in the coordination and creation of guidance, frameworks, and implementation practices for evaluation.
- b. The *USDA Evaluation Policy* will govern all program evaluations conducted by staff, external partners and contractors, and Federal award recipients who are working on the Department's behalf.
- c. This policy does not apply to evaluations of proposals, applications, quotations, or similar submissions that the Department has requested in relation to the award of contracts, grants, or cooperative agreements.

4. POLICY

- a. Definition of Evaluation:
 - (1) The *Evidence Act* defines evaluation as “an assessment using systematic data collection and analysis of one or more programs, policies, and organizations intended to assess their effectiveness and efficiency.”
 - (2) Evaluations may address questions on the implementation or institution of a program, policy, or organization.

- (3) They may address questions on the effectiveness or impact of specific strategies for or used by a program, policy, or organization.
- (4) They may also address questions on factors of variability in the effectiveness of a program, policy, or organization, or their strategies.
- (5) Evaluations can also consider questions on understanding the contextual factors around a program and how to reach specific populations or groups for an intervention.
- (6) Evaluations can provide important information to inform decisions about current and future programming, policies, and organizational operations.
- (7) Evaluations are crucial for learning and improvement purposes, as well as accountability purposes.

b. Benefits of Evaluation:

An evaluation allows for well-informed, objective policy decision making and improved programmatic implementation. Evaluations may inform and strengthen policy development and adoption, program implementation, and effectiveness, and they may build the evidence base for policy interventions. An evaluation can look beyond the program, policy, or organizational level. It may include the assessment of projects or interventions within a program, aspects of a policy, or functions within an organization. There are different types of evaluations, each of which address different questions. Office of Management and Budget (OMB) [Memorandum M-20-12](#), *Phase 4 Implementation of the Foundations for Evidence-Based Policymaking Act of 2018: Program Evaluation Standards and Practices*, provides the following definitions for specific types of evaluation:

(1) Formative evaluation:

Assesses whether a program, policy, or organizational approach – or some aspect of these – is feasible, appropriate, and acceptable before it is fully implemented. It may include process and outcome measures. However, unlike outcome and impact evaluations, which seek to answer whether the program, policy, or organization met its intended goals or had the intended impacts, a formative evaluation focuses on learning and improvement and does not aim to answer questions of overall effectiveness.

(2) Process or implementation evaluation:

Assesses how the program or service is delivered relative to its intended theory of change, and often includes information on content, quantity, quality, and structure of services provided. These evaluations can help answer the question, "Was the

program, policy, or organization implemented as intended?" or "How is the program, policy, or organization operating in practice?"

(3) Outcome or effectiveness evaluation:

Measures the extent to which a program, policy, or organization has achieved its intended outcome(s) and focuses on outputs and outcomes to assess effectiveness. An outcome evaluation can help answer the question, "Were the intended outcomes of the program, policy, or organization achieved?"

(4) Economic evaluation:

Uses methodologies that incorporate cost considerations (e.g., cost-benefit analysis, cost effectiveness analysis, program cost analysis) to determine what resources are being used in a program and how their costs compare to outcomes.

(5) Impact evaluation:

Assesses the causal impact of a program, policy, or organization, or aspect thereof, on outcomes relative to those of a counterfactual. In other words, this type of evaluation estimates and compares outcomes with and without the program, policy, or organization, or aspect thereof. Impact evaluations include both experimental (i.e., randomized controlled trials) and quasi-experimental designs. An impact evaluation can help answer the question, "Does it work, or did the intervention lead to the observed outcomes?"

c. General Framework for Conducting an Evaluation:

Program managers and staff can use the following steps as a framework for conducting an evaluation. Program managers and staff should follow these steps in order: each step is a foundation for the next.

- (1) When designing or changing a program, consider future data collection needs for evaluations. Data should be relevant, accurate, and reliable. The Department asks program managers and staff to use logic models to identify the expected outcomes and impact of the program and strengthen overall program readiness for evaluation.
- (2) Have stakeholders help inform evaluation priorities and identify data needs. Have program operations staff, program participants, and main evaluation users identify the goals, outcomes, and relevant values and standards.
- (3) Describe the program, including the need, expected effects, activities, resources, stages, context, and logic model.
- (4) Focus the evaluation design and data needed to assess key issues while using time and resources efficiently. Consider the purpose, users, uses, questions, methods,

and agreements. Evaluation design should be among the factors considered when planning a program or project.

- (5) Gather good evidence to inform and strengthen evaluation judgments and recommendations. The following parts of evidence gathering usually affect views on evidence acceptability: indicators, sources, quality, quantity, and processes and procedures.
- (6) Strengthen conclusions by linking them to the evidence gathered and judging them against values or standards set by the stakeholders. Support conclusions with these five parts: standards, analysis and synthesis, interpretation, judgment, and recommendations. Use and share lessons learned through design, preparation, feedback, follow-up, and information sharing.

d. Core Evaluation Standards and Principles:

The following standards and principles will apply to all evaluations conducted by Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices, including their external partners:

(1) Independence and Objectivity:

Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will help evaluators work independently from programmatic, regulatory, policymaking, and stakeholder activities. Agency and program leadership and staff, with input from other stakeholders, should help set evaluation priorities, identify evaluation questions, and assess the meanings of findings. However, it is important to guard evaluation functions from undue influence and bias.

To promote objectivity, Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will avoid conflicts of interest and bias during the evaluation process. After technical peer review, the USDA Evaluation Officer may approve, release, and share evaluation reports.

(2) Rigor:

Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices commit to using advanced, thorough methods that are appropriate and practical within statutory, budgetary, and other constraints. There must be rigor in all types of evaluations. Rigor requires the Department to carefully form statements about cause and effect (internal validity). It requires the Department to be clear about the population, settings, or circumstances to which evaluators can generalize results (external validity). It requires the Department to use measures that accurately capture the desired information (measurement reliability and validity).

(3) Relevance:

Evaluation priorities should consider legislative requirements and the interests and needs of agency and program leadership, program staff, and USDA partners, such as states, tribes, and grantees.

(4) Utility:

Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will make sure that all evaluations are informative for decision making about policies, priorities, and processes across Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices. This includes designing evaluation questions supporting the Learning Agenda and collecting data to answer these questions. It also includes orderly sharing the results with the public and other key stakeholders. The Department should time evaluations for use and present results in ways that are understandable and actionable. The Department should also include the findings in its planning, programmatic implementation, and budget processes.

(5) Transparency:

All stages of an evaluation – planning, implementation, and reporting – must be open to make sure findings are accountable and acceptable. Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will make information on evaluations and results widely available and accessible. This includes identifying the evaluator, releasing study plans, and describing the methods. Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will share the results of evaluations not focusing on internal management, legal, or enforcement procedures, nor generally barred from publication. Evaluation reports will show good, bad, and null results.

(6) Ethics:

Evaluations must honor the dignity, safety, and confidentiality of participants and respondents and guard participants and respondents from unnecessary risk. The Department should design them to decrease the burden on research participants and the cost to taxpayers.

e. Evaluation Practices:

When planning evaluations, Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will consider the evaluation practices described in OMB M-20-12 Appendix C, *Evaluation Practices*. They will also consider other practices for securing the quality and integrity of evaluations, or for following legal or other requirements.

f. Collaboration with Partners:

Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices should work with partners when designing and conducting evaluations. Such partners include other agencies and staff offices, other

Federal Agencies, colleges and universities, and other organizations. Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices should consider how internal and external statistical agencies' analyses can support their evaluations. These partnerships can help increase staff capacity and end excess evaluation work.

g. Implementation of the Policy:

Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices will consider the following implementation strategies from OMB M-20-12 when introducing and implementing this policy among USDA Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices.

- (1) Provide training, seminars, and other educational opportunities to make sure that Mission Area, agency, and staff office staff are aware of the policy and its role in guiding evaluation activities. The Department encourages Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices to invest in the training of key staff in evidence and evaluation through internal and external courses. Staff overseeing, conducting, and using evaluations should continually go through the relevant education, training, or supervised practice needed to learn new concepts, techniques, and skills.
- (2) Reference and require commitment to the *USDA Evaluation Policy* in funding opportunities and Federal awards to make sure that grants, contracts, and cooperative agreements for evaluations are conducted according to the Core Evaluation Standards and Principles contained in Section 4d of this policy.

h. Definitions:

See OMB [Circular A-11](#), *Preparation, Submission, and Execution of the Budget*, OMB [M-19-23](#), *Phase 1 Implementation of the Foundations for Evidence-Based Policymaking Act of 2018: Learning Agendas, Personnel, and Planning Guidance*, and OMB M-20-12 for a full list of relevant terms and definitions.

5. ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

- a. The Director, OBPA, will serve as the USDA Evaluation Officer.
- b. The USDA Evaluation Officer will:
 - (1) Execute the duties and responsibilities of the Evaluation Officer in the *Evidence Act*, OMB M-19-23, and OMB [M-21-27](#), *Evidence-based Policymaking: Learning Agendas and Annual Evaluation Plans*;
 - (2) Coordinate with relevant counterparts to systematically establish and strengthen a Departmentwide evidence framework;
 - (3) Oversee the implementation of this policy;

- (4) Oversee the Department's evaluation activities;
 - (5) Provide leadership to assess, improve, and advise on evaluation activities across USDA;
 - (6) Work to integrate performance, evidence, and risk into decision making; and
 - (7) Ensure the Department's evaluation capabilities set the tone and lead the way for Mission Areas.
- c. Mission Area Assistant Evaluation Officers (AEO) will:
- (1) Be identified, appointed, and supported by their Mission Area Head and will hold decision-making powers to serve as the AEO;
 - (2) Serve as the main point of contact for their Mission Area on evaluations;
 - (3) Ensure the evaluation functions of their Mission Area are operational and integrated into planning and decision-making processes;
 - (4) Coordinate monitoring and evaluation activities of their Mission Area; and
 - (5) Serve as the main point of contact on the USDA's Performance, Evidence, and Evaluation Committee (PEEC).
- d. The PEEC will:
- (1) Be chaired by the USDA Evaluation Officer (or designee) and facilitated by OBPA;
 - (2) Be comprised of AEOs and Mission Area, agency, and staff office evidence and evaluation personnel as members; and
 - (3) Represent the USDA Evaluation Officer's primary points of contact with Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices pertaining to evidence and evaluation matters.

6. INQUIRIES

Direct all inquiries regarding this DR to the OBPA Operations and Performance Division at obpa-deputy-directors@usda.gov or 202-720-3323.

-END-

APPENDIX A

ACRONYMS AND ABBREVIATIONS

AEO	Assistant Evaluation Officer
DR	Departmental Regulation
Evidence Act	Foundations for Evidence-Based Policymaking Act of 2018
OBPA	Office of Budget and Program Analysis
OMB	Office of Management and Budget
PEEC	Performance, Evidence, and Evaluation Committee
P.L.	Public Law
USDA	United States Department of Agriculture

APPENDIX B

AUTHORITIES AND REFERENCES

Foundations for Evidence-Based Policymaking Act of 2018, [P.L. 115-435](#), January 14, 2019

OMB, [Circular No. A-11](#), *Preparation, Submission, and Execution of the Budget*, August 2021

OMB, [M-19-23](#), *Phase 1 Implementation of the Foundations for Evidence-Based Policymaking Act of 2018: Learning Agendas, Personnel, and Planning Guidance*, July 10, 2019

OMB, [M-20-12](#), *Phase 4 Implementation of the Foundations for Evidence-Based Policymaking Act of 2018: Program Evaluation Standards and Practices*, March 10, 2020

OMB, [M-21-27](#), *Evidence-Based Policymaking: Learning Agendas and Annual Evaluation Plans*, June 30, 2021

USDA, [DR 0100-001](#), *Departmental Directives System*, January 4, 2018